

Seniors United Now Society

Position Paper on
Affordable Dental,
Optical and Auditory
Fees

Seniors, as others, can only enjoy life fully with optimal use of their physical faculties. Science and technology affords society to enjoy a fuller range of aids to allow people to live longer and healthier than before. Seniors, regardless of means, are entitled to enjoy their life to the fullest.

Why is it that less fortunate seniors are reduced to isolation and have a greater probability of injury accidents because their means are minimal and they are forced accept reduced ease in eating, seeing and hearing? (Ref. A art.X)

Issue:

Dental fees in Alberta are currently unregulated and have increased to levels that are higher than most western Canadian provinces. (fig. 2) Not all health services covered under the Alberta Health Care system are readily accessible and affordable to those on a fixed income without supplementary insurance programs.

Affordable dental, optical and auditory fee structures for retired seniors in Alberta should be incorporated into the AHC system accessible to all seniors on fixed incomes to ensure maintenance of good health throughout their retirement.

1. Background Information

- Dentistry fees are escalating at increased rates far greater than the consumer price index government sponsored pension plans tied to the federal Consumer Price Index (CPI).*
*fee increases of twice the rate of inflation in Alberta; e.g. 93% increase in Alberta from 1997 to 2013 versus a 64% average increase across Canada in the same period. (Ref. Note 2)
- Cindy Gordon, a hearing Rehab Practitioner at Bridges Support Services, hearing impaired from birth, asks “what are you still fighting for? The healthcare system must rise to meet the needs of patients with hearing loss.” Aids to Daily Living Application Benefits fund one hearing device per client when there is a critical need for both ears to function.

2. Supporting Evidence

- Refer to list of existing services covered by currently by AHC. (Ref. Notes 1a,1b,1c)
- Case study: Calgary retiree needs an affordable solution to postponed dentistry due to high dental fees and lack of personal insurance. Recommended three low cost dental units in Calgary area. (Ref. Notes 2,3,4 & 5)
- Compare the average personal lifetime production to society versus benefit assistance. Individual healthcare cost is only approximately \$6000 per capita annually. (Ref. Notes 6,7 & 8)

3. Both Sides of the Issue

- The right of professional bodies to set their own fees; i.e. private unregulated fees vs public regulated fees.
- The long term cost to the taxpayer to pay for comprehensive health care including pensioned seniors versus the higher cost of remedial emergency health solutions after the fact.

4. Conclusion

- Full health benefit coverage outweighs incremental care over the long term. Better quality of life and health will result in lower total social cost.

5. Suggested course of action

- Regulate fee maximums and set affordable comprehensive solutions which are available to all retired seniors on fixed incomes.

6. Possible solutions

- Provide comprehensive dental, optical and hearing coverage for retired persons on government income programs at a preset maximum of total benefit similar to accommodation limits (30% of income).
- Set regulated professional fee structures for all public and private care providers.
- Provide supplemental graduated incomes for all retirees based on regional cost of living.

Article X

“Low income seniors lack health basics: advocate” Katerine Dedyna/Times Colonist: Sept. 13, 2015

Notes 1a & 1b

Human Services Alberta

<http://humanservices.alberta.ca/AWonline/HB/4705.html>

03 Dental and Denturist Benefits

05 Optical Benefits

Note 1c

Alberta Aids to Daily Living benefits

<http://www.health.alberta.ca/services/AADL-benefits.html>

What isn't covered by AHCIP & Low income options

Note 2

Pain of dental fees mounts for Albertans

Matt McClure; Jan.23, 2015

<http://calgaryherald.com/news/local/pain-of-dental-fees-mounts-for-albertans>

Note 3

Optical services covered for seniors – Alberta Seniors

Note:

Refer to Dental benefits schedule & Alberta Blue Cross Dental Schedule Handbook published annually

Refer to both your own dental charges for common procedures and what your plan coverage will cover before having work done to avoid costly overages. i.e. Each dentist can set his/her own fees; often higher than scheduled in Blue Cross plans.

Note 4

Eligibility for senior's dental and optical benefits; seniors' benefit estimator

Note 5

Coverage for Seniors benefit; Dental & optical assistance; Qualifying for premium free coverage

Benefits covered under this plan; Prescription drugs; What is not covered?

Note 6

Cindy Gordon's hearing loss story

Note 7

The Globe and Mail Public Health Reporter Andre Picard May 14, 2013

'Canadians use average of \$220,000 in public health care over lifetime'

Note 8

Lifetime Distributional Effects of Publicly Financed Health Care in Canada; pp 11 to 23